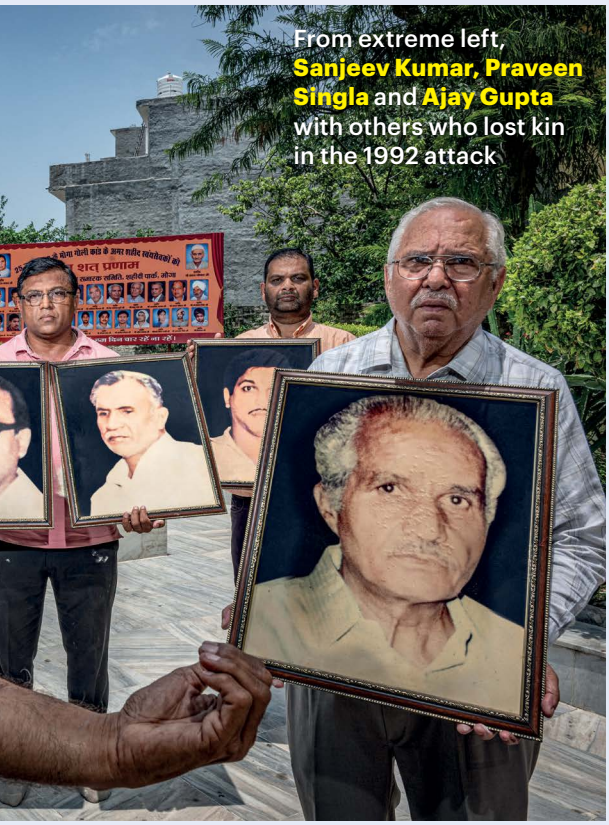


From extreme left, **Sanjeev Kumar, Praveen Singla** and **Ajay Gupta** with others who lost kin in the 1992 attack

The bullets never really left Ajay Gupta. Doctors say metal fragments are still lodged inside. He was 13 and remembers the June 25, 1989, morning like yesterday—bursts of automatic gunfire, screams, bodies dropping all around him. Ajay was one of hundreds of Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) volunteers assembled for a special shakha at Nehru Park in Moga that day, when alleged militants stormed the gathering and started firing indiscriminately. Twenty-one RSS volunteers died along with four others.

Ajay's father Bhagwan Das and his grand-uncle, Jagdish Bhagat, were among those killed. Elder brother Arun Gupta escaped unhurt. "I watched bullets tear through my father and others. Those images never leave you," says Ajay.

Sanjeev Kumar was 17 at the time and worked with the RSS's *bal swayamsevaks*, its youngest volunteers, in Moga. He survived, but the attack left him permanently disabled. It also left him a life-long sense of guilt. "Two of my young wards—Neeraj and Prabhjot, both under 10—were killed. I couldn't save them," he says.

> **"I watched bullets tear through my father and others. Those images never leave you"**
>
> **AJAY GUPTA,** who lost his father and grand-uncle in the shooting

The attackers were aiming for a much higher toll. Praveen Singla—who lost his father, Baburam Singla, and was shot in both legs—says the militants had planted bombs around the park. "One bomb exploded when people were carrying the injured to safety," he says. "The police defused another in the park and recovered a third from the hospital, where the injured had been taken."

Moga was not a one-off. Through those years, the militants frequently targeted the Hindu population. Veteran RSS pracharak Ramgopal, who is based in Moga, argues the attack was carried out to provoke Hindu outfits "so that the issue could be turned into a Hindu versus Sikh conflict". At the time, senior BJP leaders like L.K. Advani and the late Atal Bihari Vajpayee actively worked to calm the situation. "The Khalistan movement was not a Hindu versus Sikh issue; it was a militants versus society issue. This remains our considered view," says Ramgopal. The repeated attacks, though, were taking a toll on the Hindu population in Moga. Many families even thought about leaving. "The thought did arise," Ajay says. "But where could we go? Hindus were being targeted everywhere. Our businesses, properties, lives, everything was under attack. We decided we would stay put and face it."

The scars remain, though. For people like Ajay, Sanjeev and Praveen, surviving Moga was not where the story ended. It was where a harder one began: a life spent learning to live with what they cannot forget. ■

IT WAS ALSO A TIME WHEN NEW DELHI WENT THROUGH TWO MINORITY GOVERNMENTS, AND RADICALISM STARTED FILTERING INTO PARTY POLITICS WITHIN PUNJAB ITSELF

Dhuri-Hisar train, and 62 were killed, and 40 injured on a Ferozepur-Ludhiana train. The same day, terrorists shot dead 11 more, including Chamkaur Sahib candidate Jatinder Singh, part of a wave that killed 50 people—24 of them Akali Dal candidates—in an election that was ultimately countermanded.

Days earlier, on June 7, 1991, Union minister of state for home, Subodh Kant Sahay, narrowly escaped a bomb attack on his Ludhiana cavalcade; D.S. Mangat, brought in to replace K.P.S. Gill as DGP, had escaped a similar attack on February 1-2 the same year. More than 700 people died in Khalistani violence around the boycotted 1991 election, which was called off the evening before voting. By the end of the year, the murderous death toll in Punjab stood at 2,591 civilians, 497 security personnel and 2,177 terrorists.

The escalation coincided with instability in Delhi. Rajiv Gandhi's 1989 defeat gave way to two fragile minority governments under V.P. Singh and Chandra Shekhar at the Centre. Punjab's own vote reflected a surging radicalist element: the Shiromani Akali Dal (Mann), led by Simranjit Singh Mann, won six Lok Sabha seats, among them